The End Is Rooted in the Beginning: The First Taking of the Four Species

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The Daily Learning Portions

The year-round Daily Learning Portions remain the base layer. Today the season places them inside the sukkah.

- **Hebrew / secular:** 16 Tishrei 5787 · Sunday, 27 September 2026
- **Season:** Sukkot. In Israel: first day of Chol HaMoed. In the Diaspora: Second Day of Sukkot (Yom Tov). 15 Tishrei (Saturday, 26 September 2026) was Shabbat / Sukkot I, so **the first taking of the Four Species in Israel is today**, with *Shehecheyanu*.
- **Chumash:** *Vezot Haberachah*, 1st aliyah — Devarim 33:1–7, with Rashi
- **Tehillim:** Chapters 79–82
- **Tanya:** *Iggeret HaKodesh*, middle of Epistle 22
- **Rambam (3 ch.):** *Hilchot Kelim* 24–26
- **Rambam (1 ch.):** *Hilchot Gerushin* 6
- **Sefer HaMitzvot:** Day 237 — Positive Commandment 96
- **Hayom Yom:** 16 Tishrei — *Ushavtem mayim*; revelation without end; “the end is rooted in the beginning”
- **Festival overlay:** Sukkot readings as locally practiced. Diaspora Day 2 often reads Vayikra 22:26–23:44 and Bamidbar 29:12–16, haftarah I Melachim 8:2–21 (dedication of the First Temple / the Cloud filling the House). Israel Chol HaMoed weekday: the day’s *korbanot* from Bamidbar 29.
- **Ushpizin:** Yitzchak
- **History:** Yahrtzeit of R. Moshe Zacuto (Ramaz), 5458 / 1697 — Italian kabbalist, scion of *anusim*.
- **Customs:** Eat and dwell in the sukkah. Take lulav and etrog (not on Shabbat). Begin the weekday joy of *Simchat Beit HaShoeivah*. Tachanun omitted.

Opening

On 15 Tishrei the daily Chumash reached the end of the Torah: Moshe sees the Land from Nevo and dies by the mouth of Hashem, and Yehoshua is filled with the spirit of wisdom. Today the same cycle does not leap forward. It returns to the first words of the last *parshah*:

וְזֹאת הַבְּרָכָה אֲשֶׁר בֵּרַךְ מֹשֶׁה אִישׁ הָאֱלֹקִים אֶת־בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל לִפְנֵי מוֹתוֹ.

“This is the blessing.” Not a new book. The same blessing, begun again, on the morning when Israel in the Land first lifts the Four Species after a Shabbat Yom Tov.

Hayom Yom names the law of the day with surgical precision: *the end is rooted in the beginning*. The water-drawing of Sukkot is not entertainment after judgment. It is the disclosure of what teshuvah, once accepted, becomes when it is allowed to run all the way into joy. Tanya, in the same hours, forbids a subtler evasion: love of bodily life so intense that a man will not stand *face to face* with the Father who corrects him. Rambam, studying vessels that become *tamei* because they are sat upon, measures how a support receives what is placed on it. Gerushin 6 measures agency — when a deed is complete, and when a messenger has not yet delivered.

The hut is temporary. The blessing is not.

I. Chumash — Vezot Haberachah 1st (Devarim 33:1–7)

The man of G-d, before his death

Rashi, following the Sifrei, hears in *ish ha-Elokim* a double register: Moshe is a man to heaven and G-d to Pharaoh; or, he is master of the Divine Name. The blessing is given *lifnei moto* — immediately before death — because, as Rashi notes from the Sifrei, if not now, when? The Midrash and later Chassidus press further: a blessing uttered at the edge of departure is not sentiment. It is transmission. What cannot be held must be given.

Ramban reads the opening as the consummation of the covenant speeches of Devarim. After *tochachah*, after *nitzavim*, after the song of Haazinu, what remains is not another warning. What remains is *berachah*. The structure is itself a theology of the season. Elul and the Days of Awe are not the last word. Sukkot is.

“Hashem came from Sinai” — the King who approached

Devarim 33:2–5 is the most compressed geography of revelation in the Torah: Sinai, Seir, Paran, myriads of holiness, a fiery law in His right hand, even the nations offered the Torah and declining it (Rashi from Sifrei and Avodah Zarah 2b), and then:

וַיְהִי בִישֻׁרוּן מֶלֶךְ בְּהִתְאַסֵּף רָאשֵׁי עָם יַחַד שִׁבְטֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל.

There was a King in Yeshurun when the heads of the people gathered, the tribes of Israel together.

Two classical lines diverge and then meet.

One line (Rashi, Sifrei) hears *melech* as the Holy One Himself: kingship is revealed when Israel assembles. The other (some *rishonim*, and a strong current in later political readings of Devarim) hears also the earthly gathering — the people constituting a public under law. Both are Torah. Neither makes the king a source of law. The fiery law is in the right hand *before* there is a king in Yeshurun. Authority is gathered; it is not invented.

On Sukkot the same grammar is built in wood and schach. The Clouds of Glory were not Israel’s project. Israel’s project is to sit under a roof that does not pretend to be permanent, and to bless the Name who covers.

Reuven, Yehudah, Levi — life, hearing, teaching

The first three tribal blessings are not interchangeable slogans. They are offices.

Reuven (33:6): *Yechi Reuven ve'al yamot* — let Reuven live and not die, and let his men be few (or, in the other reading Rashi preserves, counted among the number). After the affair of Bilhah and the loss of the birthright, the first word Moshe speaks over a tribe is *life*. Not triumph. Continuity. Chassidus hears here the stubborn *nefesh* that remains after failure — the raw material of teshuvah. Sukkot does not deny that Reuven stumbled. It insists that he live.

Yehudah (33:7): *Shema Hashem kol Yehudah* — Hashem, hear Yehudah's voice, and bring him to his people; his hands contend for him, and You are a help against his foes. Rashi ties this to the midrash of the bones of Yehudah rolling in the coffin until Moshe prayed, and to the kings and judges who would come from him and need to be "brought to his people" — returned from war, or reconciled after the rift with the other tribes. Hearing and help: the royal tribe does not fight as an unbound will. It fights as one whose voice is heard *above*, and whose hands are helped.

Levi (33:8–9, begun in this aliyah through 33:7 and opening the next): the *tumim* and *urim*, the one who said of father and mother "I did not see them," who guards Your word and keeps Your covenant. Levi's power is real and it is limited. He teaches Jacob and Israel. He offers incense and *olah*. He does not inherit land like the others. The blessing that looks most like authority is the blessing most tightly bound to Torah.

A covenantal-republican reading, kept inside the text: differentiated offices, none of them total; kingship disclosed in assembly under prior law; the first tribe blessed with mere life after failure; the teaching tribe barred from ordinary property so that teaching not become a landed interest. Limited power is not a modern import. It is how Moshe blesses.

II. Tehillim 79–82

Asaph's sequence is not gentle festival psalmody. It is the sound of a people who have already seen the Temple breached and who still address the Shepherd.

- **79** — nations in the inheritance, Jerusalem in ruins, "help us, G-d of our salvation, for the sake of the glory of Your Name."
- **80** — *Ro'eh Yisrael ha'azinah* — Shepherd of Israel, listen; Joseph as a flock; the vine brought out of Egypt; *hashivenu* three times: restore us, let Your face shine, and we will be saved.
- **81** — the shofar of the New Moon, the statute for Joseph, "I am Hashem your G-d who brought you up from Egypt; open your mouth wide and I will fill it." The tragedy of the psalm is the next line: Israel would not listen.
- **82** — *Elokim nitzav ba'adat El* — G-d stands in the divine assembly; among the judges He judges. "How long will you judge unjustly?" The psalm that opens the heavenly court ends by asking the earthly court to do its job.

Read in Elul, these chapters are *cheshbon*. Read in the sukkah they are not cancelled. They are relocated. The Face that 80 begs to shine is the same Face Tanya will demand we not turn our backs to. The assembly of 82 is the same assembly in which Devarim 33:5 says there was a King in Yeshurun. Joy that cannot hear Asaph is not *simchat Beit HaShoeivah*. It is noise.

III. Tanya — Iggeret HaKodesh, middle of Epistle 22

The Alter Rebbe is writing about a failure that looks like piety.

There is a love for *chayei ha-guf* — the life of the body — that can even dress itself *le-shem shamayim*: I need health and ease so that I may serve with a great flame. When the body is then struck, that love "ruins the line" (*ahavah mekalkelet et ha-shurah*) and becomes a covering of the eyes. The man grows angry. He suffers out of proportion. He sends for counsel from far away rather than turning to Hashem with a low spirit and an accepted body, receiving *tochachah* as the proverb states: "For whom Hashem loves, He rebukes" (Mishlei 3:12).

The analogy is exact and hard. A compassionate, wise, and righteous father strikes his son. The wise child does not flee and does not hire intercessors against the father. He bears it *face to face* — *panim be-fanim* — because the blow is for his life.

In the Divine lexicon, *Panim* is not a metaphor for mood. *Panim* is ratzon and *cheishek*: the willingness to give all the good of the worlds, life of soul and life of body, through the Torah of Life. The Amidah says it: "For in the light of Your Face You have given us the Torah of Life." What the nations receive of bodily life without that willingness is *achorayim* — the hinder-side — and Scripture can even call that flow "other gods," not because the source is another deity, but because the mode is not Face.

To refuse suffering in love is, the Alter Rebbe says, to turn neck and back. Heaven forbid.

The previous day's portion of this same epistle warned against taking mundane advice from the Rav and distinguished hidden love from open rebuke. Today the rebuke comes home. Sukkot does not suspend the teaching. The sukkah *is* the teaching made architectural. You sit in a hut that will not defend you from weather the way a house does, and you say *leishev ba-sukkah*. You accept being uncovered in one register so that you may be covered in another. That is *panim be-fanim* in wood and schach.

Yitzchak, today's ushpiz, is the right guest for this page. His life is gevurah that consented: the *akedah*, the wells he re-dug, the laughter that had to be named because it was not obvious. Constraint that stays facing the Father becomes joy. Constraint that flees becomes anger dressed as spirituality.

IV. Rambam and Sefer HaMitzvot

Kelim 24–26 — what a support can receive

The three chapters are technical and they are not only technical.

A hide becomes susceptible to *midras* — the impurity of being sat or lain upon by a *zav* — when it is intended as a support: carpet, bedding, a hide under a child, a hide under a burden, a potter's or porter's worn hide. Five handbreadths by five. Intent without completed work often does nothing; deed without intent sometimes does nothing. A vessel whose primary identity is a receptacle, once broken for that use, may lose even the impurity of support. A vessel whose primary identity is support may keep *midras* after damage that would purify a cup.

The *halachah* is measuring contact, purpose, and identity. What you regularly place yourself upon can carry what you are. A nation that treats Torah as decoration and not as support will invent a purity it has not earned. A family that treats the sukkah as a balcony for two nights and not as a dwelling will take the blessing and miss the assignment.

Gerushin 6 — agency until delivery

The one-chapter cycle is in the laws of divorce messengers. A woman may appoint a *shaliach kabbalah*; a husband a *shaliach holachah*; the *get* does not take effect until it reaches her hand (or her receiving agent's). Status changes in the agent before delivery can void the act. Revocation must be spoken as revocation. Doubt is resolved, in many cases, toward upholding the delivered deed.

Again the season supplies the commentary without forcing it. Teshuvah that stays in the mouth of the messenger — intention, mood, a moving speech — has not yet arrived. The deed has to land. Sukkot is one of the ways it lands: you take the species in a hand, you sit in the hut, you draw water with joy. Agency is completed in a body.

Sefer HaMitzvot, Day 237 — P96

The parallel mitzvah today is Positive Commandment 96, in the taharah cluster that the three-chapter cycle is walking. The commandment does not ask for a mood. It asks for a people who can tell the difference between a carcass and a living table, between a support and a ruin, between contact that defiles and contact that sanctifies. Purity is not an aesthetic. It is law.

V. Hayom Yom — 16 Tishrei

The Tzemach Tzedek records:

In 5569 (1808) they heard from the Alter Rebbe, for the sixth time, the maamar *Ushavtem mayim* — the first of that title in *Likutei Torah*. The experience recalled the Yerushalmi (Sukkah 5:1): from the water-drawing they drew *ruach ha-kodesh*. Yonah received prophecy from that joy. "We received revelation without end. The end will be when Mashiach comes, for the end is rooted in the beginning."

Yeshayahu 12:3: *Ushavtem mayim be-sason mi-ma'ayanei ha-yeshuah*.

Three claims, none of them soft.

1. **Joy is a method of knowledge.** The Temple celebration was not a pause from seriousness. It was the technology by which spirit was drawn. A generation that can only associate holiness with the fast will not understand Sukkot, and will not understand the Tanya that insists on facing the Father rather than fleeing into emergency spirituality.
2. **Repetition is not dilution.** The sixth hearing of the same maamar was the one that felt like the Temple floor. Begin again. Today's Chumash does exactly that.
3. **The end is already in the first drawing.** Mashiach is not a different physics. He is the disclosed end of a well that was opened at the festival. The beginning — Sinai in today's aliyah, the first *ushavtem*, the first sitting in Clouds — already contains what the end will make public.

In Israel, on the morning of 27 September 2026, the Four Species were taken for the first time in 5787. The *na'anuim* to the six directions are a small anatomy of that sentence: the same Name, drawn through every axis of a life, then brought to the heart.

VI. Seasonal synthesis — from the Days of Awe into the hut

Elul asked for *cheshbon* and free will. Rosh Hashanah asked for coronation. Yom Kippur asked for *kapparah* and a future *kabbalah*. Sukkot asks whether any of that reached the body.

- If teshuvah stayed as insight, the sukkah will feel like camping.
- If teshuvah reached *panim be-fanim*, the sukkah will feel like the Father's covering — not because the weather is kind, but because the relationship is no longer in flight.
- If kingship was recited and not assembled, Devarim 33:5 will remain a verse. If heads of the people actually gather — family, minyan, public — there is a King in Yeshurun on Sukkot.

The move from *hester* to *gilui* in this season is not a mood swing. It is commanded joy after commanded return. *Venahafoch hu* is the plot of Tishrei: the same soul that stood trembling now takes a lulav and shakes it at the four winds.

Covenantal liberty here is not the liberty to be uncovered. It is the liberty of a people who accept a higher law, refuse domination by human totalness (Levi teaches and does not own the land; the King in Yeshurun appears when the tribes assemble under a law already given), and then *dwell* — not as subjects waiting for the next decree, but as children who can sit in the Father's hut without hiring intercessors against Him.

VII. Approaches and a constructive synthesis

Peshat / Sifrei–Rashi. The blessing is Moshe's last public act; the tribes receive distinct futures; Reuven is granted life; Yehudah is heard; revelation was offered widely and accepted by Israel; kingship is Hashem's among an assembled people.

Ramban and the covenantal frame. The blessing closes the book of covenant. What follows failure and song is not another rebuke. It is the assignment of roles inside a people that already swore.

Chassidus / Hayom Yom. The same week that completes and restarts the Torah is the week of drawing water. Joy is not the opposite of *tochachah*. It is what *tochachah* becomes when it is received face to face. The end is in the beginning; Mashiach is the last disclosure of the first well.

Halachic realism / Rambam. Supports receive what sits on them. Messengers have not acted until delivery. Purity and agency are facts, not metaphors. So are the Four Species and the sukkah.

Synthesis. Receive the blow without fleeing (Tanya). Bless distinct offices without inventing a total power (Chumash). Sit in a temporary house under a permanent Name (Sukkot). Draw water with joy because the well was always there (Hayom Yom). Begin the last *parshah* again because completion that does not restart is only an ending.

VIII. Practical avodah

One focus for the day, not ten:

Take the species. Sit in the hut. Do not outsource the joy.

Concretely:

1. In Israel: first *netilat lulav* with *Shehecheyanu*. Hold, bless, join, *na'anuim*, Hallel, Hoshanot. Teach the children the six directions before the minyan, not after they have already fidgeted through them.
2. One full meal in the sukkah as if it were the house — not a kiddush of convenience.
3. When irritation rises (sleep, weather, guests, the body's protest), use Tanya's test: am I turning my back, or staying *panim be-fanim*?
4. One act of *simchat Beit HaShoeivah* that a child can see — song, a guest, a walk of joy that is not sarcasm.

That is enough. The portions will keep working if the body keeps still long enough to receive them.

X. Extended Bibliography

Daily texts

- Chumash, *Vezot Haberachah* 1st: Devarim 33:1–7, with Rashi — Sefaria · Chabad with Rashi
- Tehillim 79–82 — Sefaria · Chabad Tehillim
- Tanya, Iggeret HaKodesh 22 (middle) — Chabad Daily Tanya
- Rambam, Kelim 24–26 — Chabad / Mishneh Torah
- Rambam, Gerushin 6 — Chabad Daily Rambam, 1 ch.
- Sefer HaMitzvot, Day 237 / P96 — Chabad Sefer HaMitzvot
- Hayom Yom, 16 Tishrei — Chabad Hayom Yom · Lchaim listing for 16 Tishrei 5787
- Chabad calendar day page, 27 September 2026 — chabad.org/calendar

Classical and Chassidic

- Sifrei Devarim on *Vezot Haberachah*
- Ramban on Devarim 33
- Bavli Sukkah 51b; Yerushalmi Sukkah 5:1 — water-drawing and *ruach ha-kodesh*
- Bavli Avodah Zarah 2b — Torah offered to the nations
- Mishlei 3:11–12 — *tochachah* as love
- *Likutei Torah*, maamarim *Ushavtem mayim*
- Shulchan Aruch / Alter Rebbe, Orach Chaim 639–651 — sukkah and Four Species
- Hayom Yom entries 14–16 Tishrei (gift on condition of return; binding the lulav; water-drawing)

Festival and seasonal

- Vayikra 23:33–44; Bamidbar 29:12–16
- I Melachim 8:2–21 — Cloud in the House (Diaspora haftarah, Day 2)
- Yeshayahu 12:3

Covenantal-republican (used only where the text already speaks)

- Philip Pettit, *Republicanism: A Theory of Freedom and Government* — non-domination as freedom from arbitrary power
- Eric Nelson, *The Hebrew Republic* — early-modern readings of biblical peoplehood and limited rule
- Deuteronomic assembly texts as prior law over office (Devarim 17; 33:5)

Credit

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